

Photo credit: The Yellow Company.

Julia Spicer, OAM, is a Queensland drought resilience champion.

Even as her Goondiwindi home flooded, she kept working on the Regional Drought Resilience Planning (RDRP) project that won the [Australian Institute of Project Management's \(AIPM\) 2022 Government Project of the Year award](#).

The accolade follows the win for both the Queensland 2022 Government Project of the Year and the Overall Queensland Project of the Year awards.

The foundational year of the Future Drought Fund's RDRP program saw regional drought resilience plans developed in 23 regions across Australia.

As Regional Facilitator for the Darling Downs and Southwest Queensland regions, Julia's determination and commitment during one of Queensland's wettest years is typical of the RDRP team across the state.

Julia said one of her biggest challenges was engaging online with regional farmers and communities to ask about their experiences of drought, in the middle of a major flood event.

'We had to rely on virtual get-togethers and meetings, we re-jigged our whole in-person meeting schedule,' she said.

'We had fairly raw conversations about drought and its challenges, it was a tough time to have to ask about this.

'I had to say "Hi, you don't really want to talk to us right now, but we need to - even when so much else is going on".

'My personal relationships were on the line, I had to make sure people didn't feel taken advantage of.

'It was much more stressful than trying to get water out of our house!

'But these meetings made people feel comfortable to talk about a very uncomfortable subject, they felt respected in the consultation process even though the timing wasn't of their choosing.

'In the end, people felt heard, they felt understood, and we were able to show them the plans we put together with their input, after the consultations were over.'

Photo credit: Julia Spicer AOM.

The Queensland RDRP project team coordinated more than 370 engagement activities with almost 200 regional community stakeholders to deliver 5 drought resilience plans as part of a pilot jointly funded by the Queensland and Australian Governments.

Project spokesperson and Managing Director of The Yellow Company, Ben Norling, said they were very proud of the AIPM award win.

‘The best time to prepare for drought is before it happens,’ he said.

‘Julia and other rural-based facilitators continued to work regardless of circumstances, meeting online through confronting challenges.

‘Many flood-hit regions were in drought only a few years ago and will inevitably experience it again.’

‘Central to the project’s success was engaging local resources and people to deliver the pilot project.

‘The team’s ability to deliver outcomes for regional stakeholders despite all the challenges deserves commendation.’

‘Those in the regions appreciated having someone like Julia in Goondiwindi, who can personally relate to their experiences.’

A businesswoman and Order of Australia recipient, in late 2022 Julia Spicer was announced as Queensland’s first regional Chief Entrepreneur, a voluntary role in the Queensland Government.

She said having local people in key regional facilitator roles was key to the Regional Drought Resilience Planning project.

‘I was having conversations with people who know me and have worked with me before – we weren’t starting from scratch.’

The Regional Drought Resilience Planning project’s pilot phase has already delivered promising results.

Photo credit: The Yellow Company.

An independent evaluation of the project across the state found stakeholders had gained a new understanding of drought and its impacts on their regions, producers, and communities.

The second round has started across 9 remaining regions and will roll out until 2024.

Project partners include the Future Drought Fund, Queensland’s Department of Agriculture and Fisheries, the Rural Economies Centre of Excellence and The Yellow Company.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/qld-regional-drought-resilience-planning-project-wins-major-award>